THE BANGLADESH WAR, 1971

Separated by 1,600km of Indian territory, Pakistan's two 'wings' shared a common religion but their cultural and linguistic differences were considerable. Decades of escalating unrest in East Pakistan culminated in Major Ziaur Rahman of the Pakistan Army declaring Bangladesh's independence on 26 March 1971. Under pressure to recognize the state of Bangladesh and take active measures to resolve the crisis, India preferred to support a long-term insurgency. Existing contingency plans were limited to defending the 'chicken's neck' corridor linking north Bengal with India's other north-eastern states.

On 1 May, HQ Eastern Command was instructed to raise, equip and train East Bengal cadres for guerrilla operations. The evolving plan for an offensive into East Pakistan specified three objectives: first, to capture Chittagong and Khulna and prevent further Pakistani reinforcement; second, to secure key river crossings and airfields; and third, to split the Pakistani forces into 'penny packets'. In the west, both the Western and Southern commands were to maintain a defensive posture. Western Command was allocated XV Corps, I Corps and XI Corps. Southern Command was responsible for the sector from Ganganagar to the Rann of Kutch. India had one armoured and 13 infantry divisions, four independent armoured and three independent infantry brigades in the west. Five mountain divisions defended the Chinese border.

During June–October, the Indian Army carried out many cross-border operations including the destruction or capture of outposts. From mid-October, Indian troops conducted operations up to 16km inside East Pakistan, with the areas captured handed over to the Bangladesh armed forces. In preparation for an offensive into East Pakistan, 4 Mountain and 9 Infantry divisions were placed under a newly raised II Corps headquarters; IV Corps headquarters was moved from the north and allotted the two divisions operating in the Naga and Mizo hills.

By October, the refined Indian plan saw the theatre divided into four sectors. In the north-western sector, north of the Padma River and west of